Nursing Essentials

Priority: Assess function, feeding, and physiologic stability. Withdrawal signs overlap with infection, hypoglycemia, and other illnesses.

FOCUS 1

Recognize

- **Possible findings:** tremors, high-pitched cry, irritability, poor sleep, feeding difficulty, vomiting, or loose stools.
- **Timing varies:** onset depends on the substance, exposure pattern, and infant; symptoms may appear after the first day.
- **Terminology:** NOWS refers specifically to neonatal opioid withdrawal; NAS is a broader term.

FOCUS 2

Soothe

- **Nonpharmacologic care:** reduce stimulation, use safe soothing / swaddling, support rooming-in when appropriate, and protect rest.
- **Feeding:** monitor intake, weight, hydration, and skin integrity; tailor feeding support to the infant.
- **Assessment:** use the unit's validated approach, such as Eat, Sleep, Console; medication follows the clinical pathway.

FOCUS 3

Distinguish

- **FASD:** a spectrum of possible growth, learning, behavioral, and neurologic effects.
- **Fetal alcohol syndrome:** may include characteristic facial features, growth impairment, and central nervous system involvement.
- **No facial finding required:** absence of a characteristic appearance does not exclude alcohol-related developmental effects.

Care for the whole family

Make it stick: A calm environment is treatment, but a quiet or sleepy infant is not automatically improving. Reassess feeding, breathing, arousal, and perfusion.

Focus	What to know	Nursing application
Breastfeeding	assess medications, substance use, and clinical factors individually with the care team.	Assess feeding safety
Connect support	treatment resources, safe caregiving, follow-up, and developmental services when needed.	Arrange family support
Use respectful language	describe exposure and care needs without blame; no known safe amount of alcohol exists during pregnancy.	Use respectful counseling

RED FLAGS · ESCALATE PROMPTLY

Apnea, respiratory distress, seizures, fever, dehydration, or poor perfusion must not be attributed to withdrawal without urgent assessment.